Context Is a Pipeline, Not a Window: Information Attrition in LLM Agent Harnesses

Anonymous Author(s)
Submitted for double-anonymous review

Abstract—LLM agents are judged by two numbers: the size of the context window, and how often the final answer is correct. Both numbers miss a third thing: how much of a tool's output is lost before the model ever sees it. We measured this loss in a real tool-using agent. The agent finds the cause of injected faults by reading Linux kernel traces. The context window was almost empty: across 720 runs, the single largest prompt used only 5.75% of it. Yet a third of all tool results (3,827 of 11,189) were cut before they reached the model, and every cut result became broken JSON. This loss followed a clear pattern. The harness cut each result by slicing its JSON text at a fixed length. A slice like this does not shorten a result evenly. It deletes whatever data sits near the end. One field reached the model in only 4.7% of calls. A second field, in the very same results, reached the model in 99.3% of calls. Which field held the fault's evidence depended on when the faulty process started: early or late in the trace. The agent's diagnosis accuracy matched this same split, almost exactly. So we ran controlled experiments to test one question: did the data loss cause the drop in accuracy? This paper makes four contributions. First, we model an agent's context as a five-stage pipeline, with a measured failure at each stage. Second, we replay 864 real tool results, including one from a production trace where the shipped cut deletes all 128 records of the fault's evidence. Third, a controlled experiment shows that the cut's real cost appears first as extra work, not as wrong answers: 43% more tool calls, twice the computation, and yield falling from 0.61 to 0.31. The agent still finds the right answer when it has another way to reach it. Fourth, a survey of seven agent frameworks finds two that cut tool output the same unsafe way, with no consistent, safer alternative in the rest. Whether the data cut truly causes the accuracy drop is still an open question. A repeated test on real production data shows the same pattern again, but it does not settle the question.

Index Terms—LLM agents, agent harnesses, context engineering, empirical evaluation

I. Introduction

An agent never reads its context window directly. It reads whatever its harness, the code that wraps the model, decided to put there. Between a tool producing a result and the model seeing it, the harness serializes it, cuts it to a budget, keeps or drops parts across turns, and passes it between phases. Every one of these steps is a design choice. Every one of them can lose information.

Most research on agent context asks how big the window is and how the model attends within it [1], or how to extend it with memory [2]. Work on agent harnesses treats the surrounding code as a minor detail [3], [4]. One recent study reads the source code of eleven production harnesses, but does not measure what happens to the data [6]. Failure taxonomies label what went wrong across thousands of agent runs [5], but a label is not a loss measurement. Three recent studies come closer to ours. One asks how well a model uses a tool's complete output [7]; we ask whether the output is complete in the first place. One measures how a harness's design changes outcomes across models and tasks [8]; we trace that variance to one measurable loss point, not the outcome. One shows that storing tool output in a file for retrieval, instead of context, costs accuracy on some models but not others [9]; our cause is different: destructive delivery, not a retrieval choice. The gap all of this work shares: a run log records what a tool delivered, not what it produced. A loss on the way into the log cannot be found in the log.

We measured this gap in an agent that finds the root cause of injected faults from Linux kernel traces. Three facts came out of that measurement.

First, the window was nearly empty. Across all 720 runs, the single largest prompt we sent was only 23k tokens, against a 400k window. That is 5.75%.

Second, a third of all tool results were destroyed before they reached the model. The harness did this by cutting long results at a fixed point in the text. JSON always lists its keys in the same order, so a cut like this does not shorten a result evenly, it deletes whichever keys come later, completely. One list of containers reached the model in only 4.7% of 742 calls. A second list, sitting right next to it in the same payload, reached the model in 99.3% of calls.

Third, the damage lined up exactly with the task we asked the agent to solve. A fault that starts a new process during the trace shows up in the early list, the one that survives. A fault in a container that was already running shows up only in the late list, the one that dies. Diagnosis accuracy split along that same line, on both test applications: faults that spawn a new process scored 40–55 out of 60; faults in containers already running scored 0–24 out of 60. We used to think this gap was just a limit of what kernel traces can show. The delivery numbers say otherwise: our own harness is partly responsible. How large a part is still an open question. We report what our experiments settled, and what they did not.

Our contributions are four. (1) A five-stage pipeline model of an agent's context, with a measured failure at each stage, and an instrument to measure it: per-

Replication package: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23614755

stage counts and one yield number, applied to our own harness (Sec. II). (2) Replay evidence, including a case where the shipped cut deletes an entire evidence class at production scale (Sec. III). (3) A registered, controlled experiment whose result is a compensation tax: when the agent has another way to reach the answer, the cut costs it work, not accuracy (Sec. IV). (4) A survey of seven agent frameworks: two of them cut tool output the same unsafe way, and the rest offer no consistent, safer alternative (Sec. III).

II. Context as a Pipeline

Picture one diagnostic run. The agent calls a tool, say a container listing, and gets a result back (produced). The harness turns that result into text and fits it inside a budget before the model ever reads it (delivered). The agent splits its investigation across several workers, subtasks with their own limit on tool-calling turns; a worker acts on what it receives, turn by turn (act), and keeps only so much conversation history before older turns get dropped (retain), a separate limit of its own. A worker that computes something worth reporting must hand it off to whatever writes the final verdict (transfer); if it does not, the computation is lost even though it happened. Nothing here carries to the next run (persist); we turn that off by design, to keep runs independent. We model this five-step path as five boundaries (Table I), which fail in different ways that matter for how to read it. S1 and S4 destroy evidence outright: a result or a finding is simply gone, as if it never existed. S2 does not destroy anything; it cuts a worker off before it finishes, so some work never happens at all. S3 does not destroy anything either; it only makes a run more expensive, by resending history that did not need resending. S5 looks absent in our setup, but that is a choice, not a failure: we turned it off on purpose, so one run cannot leak into the next. We still call all five one pipeline, because each is a point where the harness decides what survives to the next step. That is what they share. How they fail is not it.

The loss at a boundary is not random: it depends on how the cutting rule interacts with the shape of the data. If a result keeps a fixed key order and the cut is a prefix slice, whether a field survives depends only on its position in the text. Nothing makes a late field less important than an early one, yet models already attend unevenly to position inside the window [1]. The harness makes this worse: a field past the cut is not attended to less, it is gone before attention ever gets the chance to see it.

Table I's numbers answer only how often each boundary fails, not whether a failure changes the final answer; a correlation in field data does not prove that. Section IV answers that question directly, by re-introducing one boundary's failure at a time, with everything else held fixed.

Measuring the loss. We propose instrumenting these boundaries and reporting, next to accuracy, how much produced evidence survived each one, with a concrete unit at each boundary. At S1, the unit is a top-level field of a tool result, counted as delivered when its content is present in the text the model receives (whether the payload still parses is reported separately). At S4, the unit is a recorded finding or a captured computation, counted as transferred when it reaches the phase that decides. Our summary number, yield, is findings recorded divided by computations run: a narrow, measurable proxy for "work that reached the decision," not for relevance, which needs ground truth and is future work.

TABLE I
The five boundaries, and the failure found at each one. S1–S4 come from the harness's own field data, collected before the controlled experiment in Sec. IV; S5 is a design choice, not a measured failure. These rows show how often each boundary fails. Whether that failure changes the final answer is a separate question, tested only by the controlled experiment.

	Boundary	Measured failure (field data)
S1	produce → deliver	720-run eval: prefix slicing, 34% of results cut, all broken; one field delivered 4.7% vs 99.3%
S2	deliver → act	554-worker campaign: the step budget is a wall, 51% of workers stopped at exactly the limit
S3	act → retain	one before/after run: raising retention 80k to 150k chars moved it from 303k to 545k tokens
S4	retain → transfer	same 554-worker campaign: hand-off is voluntary, 98 workers passed on nothing; silence reads as "nothing found"
S5	transfer → persist	by design, not measured: nothing survives the run (to keep runs independent)

III. The Defect, Measured

A. In the field

We now give the full numbers behind Table I's S1 row, from the harness's deployed evaluation: 720 runs, 11,189 tool results. Of those, 3,827 were cut, and every one broke. Inside the cut results, one field reached the model in only 4.7% of 742 calls; a second field, in the same results, reached it in 99.3%.

This is a separate point from accuracy: the scores we give elsewhere (the 40–55 versus 0–24 split in the introduction) come from a strict scorer, which only counts an answer correct when the agent names the right container against ground truth, not from an earlier, lenient scorer that counted any mention in passing. We caught that scorer's mistake and replaced it before running our controlled experiment.

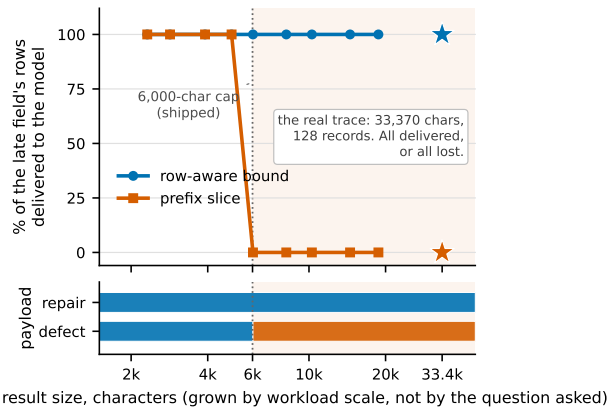


Fig. 1. The delivery cliff. We build a result with the real tool's shape and replay it through both cutting rules as it grows past the shipped 6,000-character cap. No model is involved. Under the prefix slice, the late field arrives whole until the cap, then vanishes entirely and the payload breaks (bottom strip). The row-aware cut keeps every field at every size. The stars mark where the real production trace (Sec. III-B) falls: 33,370 characters, 128 records, delivered or lost whole, exactly as predicted.

B. Mechanism and replays

Section II explained why a prefix slice loses data by position. Here we show that this is not just a theory: it is deterministic, and it holds on real, recorded data (Fig. 1). For every tool call, our transcripts store both the full result and the text actually sent to the model. We replayed 864 recorded results, from 31 runs, through both cutting rules: the shipped prefix slice and the repaired row-aware cut. Every result over the budget broke under the prefix slice, every time; none broke under the row-aware cut. The tools that overflow the budget are the ones that list things: 50% of process-listing calls broke, along with 43% of the agent's own analysis outputs and 1% of small summaries. Only 2.5% of all calls were affected at all, which is exactly why this defect survives inspection: quiet on most calls, fatal on the few that matter.

We then replayed the shipped cut on one production-scale trace: a real 21-container deployment, with one service held under a CPU limit. The culprit here is what we later call quiet (Sec. IV): already running before the trace starts, with no second, independent way for the agent to spot it. It is one Java container among five, each close to 1.4% of kernel events, so it does not stand out by size either. The listing result for this trace is 33,370 characters, 5.6× the shipped budget; we tuned nothing, that is simply how big a real result gets. The shipped slice delivers 30 of 118 early-list records, but 0 of 128 late-list records, in an already broken payload. On real deployed data, at the real budget, this culprit's entire class of evidence disappears before the model sees it.

C. The same cut in other frameworks

A defect found in a single harness would be a narrow result. To test how general it is, we examined the tool-output cutting code in current releases of seven agent frameworks (langchain-core 1.6.12, langchain 1.4.6, smolagents 1.26.0, openai-agents 0.24.0, autogen-agentchat 0.7.5, pyautogen 0.10.0, crewai 0.11.2). We found two general-purpose cutters, both slicing by position, just like ours. langchain-core slices serialized tool output down to 500 characters, keeping only the front; smolagents deletes the middle of any observation over 20k characters. Neither looks at the structure of what it cuts. Three frameworks do not cut tool output at all, which just moves the same loss further along, into the context window instead. One framework cuts only its own tracing data. We found one structure-aware cutter: a shell middleware that cuts by whole lines and says so. It shows the safe pattern exists. It is just not the default.

IV. The Controlled Experiment

The field numbers show that delivery and accuracy move together: a match, not a cause. There is also a confound: when we fixed the delivery boundary, we also shipped two new analysis tools, so an accuracy gain in the field data could come from those tools, not the fix. To separate cause from confound, we put each defect back on its own, one at a time, holding the agent, tools, task, and model fixed. We wrote down our predictions before each wave of runs. Every change to the plan is logged, with its date and reason, in a file that ships with the artifact.

Setup. The subjects are kernel traces of a coding agent running under resource limits, with exact ground truth. The diagnosing agent, model (temperature 0), tools, and task all stay fixed. There are two fault classes: in spawned faults, the culprit process starts partway through the trace; in resident faults, it was already running. Healthy traces serve as negative controls, and every run gets the same one-line symptom report.

We test six configurations. Repaired is the fixed version: row-aware cut, automatic hand-off. S1 defect re-introduces just the prefix-slice cut, at the budget that bites on these traces. S1 reversed keeps that defect, but serializes keys in reverse order, so only position changes, not content. An order-only control reverses keys with no cut, isolating the effect of reordering alone. Single-defect arms re-introduce S2 through S4 one at a time. All defects re-introduces all five together, matching the original shipped harness.

Each fault class has 5 distinct recordings, times 3 repeats, paired across configurations: 145 runs total, none failed. Scoring counts only a commitment: the agent must name the culprit in its answer field, checked against ground truth, not a mention in passing. Our first scorer counted mentions instead, inflating one arm's score from 2/15 to 14/15; we caught the mistake auditing at 46 runs and replaced the scorer.

Results (Table II). The window was never the limit: a run used a median 567k input tokens, over a median 53 calls, about 10k per call, just 2.5% of the 400k window at that median. Under the defect, the agent lost a median 27 results per run, 40% of its calls, every one broken. It

TABLE II
The cut changes the price, not the answer. Medians over the 15 spawned-culprit runs per configuration (5 recordings × 3 repeats; order-only has 10). Yield = findings recorded ÷ computations run.

	correct	calls	cut/run	comp.	yield	tokens
repaired	14/15	53	0	18	0.61	(567k)
S1 defect	15/15	68	27	32	0.34	+5%
S1 reversed	15/15	76	30	36	0.31	+14%
order only	10/10	48	0	16	0.61	−12%

still named the spawned culprit in 15/15 runs, against 14/15 for the repaired condition. That difference is noise at this sample size, not a sign the defect helps. What moved was the work. From repaired to S1 defect to S1 reversed, tool calls rose from 53 to 68 to 76: a 28% rise, then a 43% rise. Computations rose the same way, from 18 to 32 to 36, roughly doubling. Input tokens rose 5%, then 14%. Yield fell from 0.61 to 0.34 to 0.31, because the agent runs more computations without finding more, not because it finds less: findings stay at 11 throughout. The order-only control, changing only key order and cutting nothing, lands back at 0.61 too, confirming yield measures the real effect, not reordering. At equal answers, the extra tokens are unnecessary inference cost that will not show up in end-to-end latency.

The reversal test, and a refuted prediction. We predicted that reversing the key order would move the culprit's list from fully delivered to fully deleted, so accuracy should drop. The manipulation worked as planned: transcripts show the culprit absent from every listing payload. Yet the agent still named it, 15/15. It recovered the name differently: the culprit, the loudest process in the trace at 14.0% of kernel events, lands in the first rows of every sorted table the agent builds, the part that survives. The order-only control stayed flat, so this recovery is real, not an artifact of the scoring. Our original prediction was wrong. What replaces it is a sharper rule: the cut hurts only where the agent has no second route to the answer, and its cost shows up as extra work before it shows up as errors. A loud culprit survives the loss of any single route. A quiet culprit that lives in one field, like the resident case in the field data, delivered at just 4.7%, has no second route.

A direct replay, repeated, at production scale. Three early attempts to show the cut destroying accuracy, not data, failed: with no working repaired baseline there was nothing to compare against. We then fixed two things: delivery, so results are never truncated mid-record, and the step budget, giving workers more tool-calling turns before stopping. We also built a page-on-request mechanism, a safety net for oversized results that never fired here, since every result fit on the first page. We reran the same trace and prompt under both conditions. Repaired: 3 of 6 runs name the throttled service correctly, 0 of 6 broken payloads. S1 defect: 0 of 5 correct, every run broken, 10 to 14 payloads each. The data-destruction result holds with no exceptions at production scale too. The accuracy half moves the same direction but is noisier here: three of six repaired runs were still wrong, for reasons unconnected to data loss. We read this as a direct, repeated replication of the mechanism at deployed scale, not proof the cut alone drives the field-wide split.

V. Why Nobody Notices

Three things hide this class of defect. First, it costs almost no time: in kernel traces from two production coding agents (10 uncapped runs), waiting on the model ate a median 84% of wall clock (range 80–91%, network and queueing included). The defect's real cost, in correctness and token spend, barely touches that metric, the one teams actually watch. Second, capacity looks fine: a window barely touched gives no hint that evidence is being discarded upstream. Third, the usual remedy hides the symptom: handing the agent a written procedure reached the same verdict as free exploration, at just 35% of the tokens. Teams that feel context pressure add structure, see an improvement, and stop looking there. It is the right fix for the wrong reason: it needs less delivered evidence, instead of delivering evidence better.

VI. Threats to Validity

One harness, one domain, one model: we argue the defect class is general because the pipeline itself is unavoidable, and two of the seven surveyed frameworks cut the same way, with no consistent alternative (Sec. III). The same shape recurs whenever a harness truncates a compiler error, a CI log, or a failing test's output before a coding agent gets to see it. We have not measured other harnesses end to end, nor a conventional build-test-fix coding agent; the evidence here is kernel traces only. We also wrote the defect ourselves, so the experiment reintroduces it under registered predictions, not as a repair story. On scale: 5 recordings per class, with paired repeats of the same five recordings, not five independent fault instances. The experiment's budget is scaled to fit its smaller traces; the production-scale replay keeps the shipped budget. The accuracy half of the field split remains correlation, not cause.

VII. Future Plans

(1) The causal accuracy experiment. Pick a fault family with a known-succeeding repaired agent and a quiet culprit. Hold the trace, fault, prompt, model, and tools fixed, varying only delivery: complete, prefix-truncated, reversed-key-order, row-aware, and paging-on-request (not yet seen to fire). For every run, report whether the culprit's records are visible, whether the payload is valid, whether the culprit is recoverable elsewhere, and the final answer, across independent instances. (2) A deeper survey. Extend our reading to the eleven-harness corpus of [6], classify each cutter as position- or structure-based, and replay it against the delivery cliff. (3) Reporting loss as standard practice. Package the instrument so any harness can print

its loss profile beside its accuracy number, to test whether equal-accuracy harnesses differ in yield and predict harder-task performance. (4) Tests without a model. Each failure in Table I is mechanical, so CI can catch it: a cut result that fails, a step budget at its limit, a dropped computed result. A replication package (drivers, scorer, results, replay corpus, registered plan) is included (see footnote on page 1).

VIII. Conclusion

An agent's context is not a window: it is a pipeline's output. That pipeline destroyed a third of all tool results while the window sat 93% empty, deleting evidence by position, not value. Where the agent had another route, the loss cost extra work, not accuracy. Every harness makes these choices and none reports them. They are easy to measure. We have shown how.

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